

First Read

Greater China Banks

Marketing feedback: interest resurges

Equities

Asia

Banks, Ex-S&L

Decent investor interest in China banks amid market volatility

During our Singapore marketing trip this week, we met with 23 large investment funds, most of which were long-only funds. Discussions focused on banks' underlying earnings trends, investor positioning and fund flows, deposit migration, and the implications of China's recent tightening of cross-border investment and wealth flows. Compared with previous trips, investors asked fewer questions on China's macro outlook and policy direction, except around interest rate trends and potential stimulus. Most investors appeared to agree that risks from the property downturn and LGFV NPLs have passed their peak, while retail consumer credit risk is becoming a bigger concern. ABC and ICBC's capital-raising plans, as well as the impact of AI adoption, were also raised. Overall, we saw rising interest in the China banks sector, which investors generally viewed as an alternative defensive dividend-yield play to AI and growth stocks amid market volatility.

More interest in SOE China banks than JSBs; strong interest in HK banks

SOE banks deliver stronger revenue growth in 1Q26 driven by corporate loan growth and stabilizing NIM than the JSBs. Investors generally preferred CCB, supported by its above-peer ROE, capital ratio and decent provision buffer; CCB-A has also outperformed YTD. Some investors compared CCB with ICBC, while others questioned whether ABC should continue to trade at a premium to its Big-4 peers. By contrast, CMB was mentioned less often than before, reflecting concerns over its slow retail business and profit growth, though its A-shares offer an attractive 5.2% dividend yield. There was also interest in CITIC Bank and leading regional banks such as BONB, BOHZ and BOCD. In addition, following the latest tighter regulation on China's offshore investments and tax collection, investors were keen to understand the implications for HK banks, particularly HSBC and STAN, whose share prices fell on the news.

Our thoughts on cross-border wealth flows and implications to HK banks

On the potential slowdown in cross-border wealth flows, we believe banks should generally be less affected than HK insurers and brokers. Within HK banks, BOCHK should be relatively less exposed, given its likely lower revenue contribution from mainland China clients' wealth business. Even for HSBC and STAN, net new money remains relatively small compared with China's massive trade surplus of US\$1.2tn in 2025 and broader cross-border flows, while the revenue contribution from mainland Chinese clients is reportedly limited. We believe the recent regulatory tightening is intended to improve transparency around offshore assets held by Chinese corporates and individuals, and to enforce China's global taxation rules more firmly. Legitimate cross-border fund flows should still be able to continue, although the tightening could create a sentiment overhang for HK banks. In the near term, heightened risk aversion may support the outperformance of China bank stocks.

Prefer high-yield SOE banks and quality regional banks; constructive on BOCHK

We remain constructive on China bank stocks, particularly those offering dividend yields above 5%. Upcoming [2Q results should further reaffirm improving fundamentals](#), supported by NIM stabilisation and solid NII growth, although SOE banks' revenue growth may ease slightly to 7.6% YoY in 2Q from 8.5% in 1Q due to a high base. We expect net profit growth to remain broadly stable QoQ, after rising 3.5% YoY in 1Q. Market rotation is now rapid, and banks should become attractive at certain points. Among individual names, we like CCB, ICBC, BOC, CITIC, BONB and BOHZ. Within HK banks, we are also constructive on [BOCHK, where solid 2Q results and a potential special DPS announcement could serve as positive catalysts](#).

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Valuation Method and Risk Statement

We derive our price targets for H-share China banks based on a three-stage dividend discount model (DDM). We derive our price targets for A-share China banks based on P/B to ROE valuation methodology.

We think major risks to China banks include: 1) deterioration in asset quality, underpinned by a soft macro environment and domestic property market activity; 2) risks related to capital adequacy and dilution led by refinancing; and 3) downside in interest rates and the consequent pressure on bank profitability.

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Company Name	Reuters	12-month rating	Price	Price date
Agricultural Bank of China ^{7,18}	1288.HK	Neutral	HK\$5.86	07 Aug 2026
Agricultural Bank of China - A ^{7,18}	601288.SS	Neutral	Rmb6.47	07 Aug 2026
Bank of Beijing	601169.SS	Neutral	Rmb5.01	07 Aug 2026
Bank of China ^{2,4,16,7,18,6c}	3988.HK	Buy	HK\$5.23	07 Aug 2026
Bank of China (Hong Kong) ^{16,28,7,6a,6b}	2388.HK	Neutral	HK\$50.20	07 Aug 2026
Bank of Communications ^{7,18}	3328.HK	Buy	HK\$7.25	07 Aug 2026
Bank of Communications - A ^{7,18}	601328.SS	Buy	Rmb6.91	07 Aug 2026
Bank of Hangzhou	600926.SS	Buy	Rmb16.00	07 Aug 2026
Bank of Nanjing	601009.SS	Buy	Rmb11.21	07 Aug 2026
Bank of Ningbo ⁷	002142.SZ	Buy	Rmb31.48	07 Aug 2026
China CITIC Bank ^{28,7,18}	0998.HK	Buy	HK\$7.34	07 Aug 2026
China Construction Bank ^{16,28,7,18}	0939.HK	Buy	HK\$8.79	07 Aug 2026
China Merchants Bank ^{16,28,7,18,6a,6b}	3968.HK	Neutral	HK\$48.68	07 Aug 2026
China Merchants Bank - A ^{16,28,7,18,6a,6b}	600036.SS	Buy	Rmb38.80	07 Aug 2026
China Minsheng Banking ^{28,7,18}	1988.HK	Buy	HK\$3.44	07 Aug 2026
China Minsheng Banking - A ^{28,7,18}	600016.SS	Buy	Rmb3.53	07 Aug 2026
China Vanke ^{4,18,6c}	000002.SZ	Sell	Rmb3.22	07 Aug 2026
China Vanke - H ^{4,18,6c}	2202.HK	Sell	HK\$2.50	07 Aug 2026
Chongqing Rural Commercial Bank ¹⁸	3618.HK	Buy	HK\$6.19	07 Aug 2026
Huishang Bank	3698.HK	Neutral	HK\$4.71	07 Aug 2026
Industrial & Commercial Bank of China ^{16,7,18}	1398.HK	Buy	HK\$7.14	07 Aug 2026
Industrial & Commercial Bank of China A ^{16,7,18}	601398.SS	Neutral	Rmb7.53	07 Aug 2026
Postal Savings Bank of China ¹⁸	1658.HK	Neutral	HK\$4.84	07 Aug 2026
Postal Savings Bank of China ¹⁸	601658.SS	Neutral	Rmb4.96	07 Aug 2026

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